

Week 7: Pantheism

BIG IDEA

Pantheism, the dominant Eastern worldview, teaches that god is in all and is all: a divine spark in everything, with no distinction between creator and creation. It has reached the West through karma, meditation, yoga, and Star Wars, and losing the Creator-creation distinction drives us straight back to idolatry.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Pantheism dominates Eastern culture, but karma, meditation, yoga, and Star Wars' 'force' show it has made its way West, so students must learn to identify it.
- Pantheism says god is literally part of everything, rocks, trees, all of nature, a divine essence; this differs from the Holy Spirit dwelling in believers.
- The key word is distinction: naturalism says there is no God, pantheism says God exists but is not distinct from creation.
- At the Areopagus Paul helps the Stoics, who believed much like modern pantheists, see that God is personal and near yet distinct and other than us.
- Without distinction everything is as divine as God, so worshiping rocks and trees is no different; losing the distinction leads to the root of sin, idolatry.
- A God who is distinct, holy, and outside ourselves gives us a standard for right and wrong, just and unjust, love and hate.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Where do you see pantheistic ideas, like karma or a divine force, showing up in movies, music, or wellness culture?
2. Why does the distinction between Creator and creation matter so much? What is lost without it?
3. How does losing that distinction lead to idolatry, even in subtle forms like elevating self, people, or causes?
4. How can we show another worldview is inconsistent while still speaking in love, without making fun of it?

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LEADER VIDEO — FULL TRANSCRIPT

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why pantheism matters

- 0:05 If naturalism is the dominant view of the West, pantheism is the dominant view of the East. Pantheism is interesting, and it may seem like much of pantheistic thought is far from your students. Even though it largely dominates Eastern culture, from Hindus to Buddhists and a bunch of others in that part of the world, it has made its way to the West — and in a really strange way. So you might think, for your youth group: why are we talking about pantheism? Why are we bothering with this? That's another part of the world, and I'm not taking my kids on a mission trip over there, so do I really need to spend an entire week dedicated to this sort of Eastern thought?
- 0:57 Well, do you like Star Wars? Have you ever heard of karma, meditation, even yoga? All of these things come from pantheistic thought, or a pantheistic worldview. So naturally, we cannot ignore its influence. We have to address it, we have to discuss it, and we have to get our students to understand what it exactly is, so that they can identify it and navigate through it successfully.

What pantheism teaches

- 1:27 So what is pantheism? What are we talking about? Essentially, think of it this way: the idea of God — and I'm going to write God with a small g — is in all. Now, you can even say, more specifically, God is all. In Christianity we talk about the idea of the Holy Spirit being within us, right? So God is in us, and that's sort of the idea. Jesus comes, Jesus goes, He sends the Spirit, and the Spirit dwells within us. We have this idea of God in us — not just God with us, but God in us. Okay, that's great, but that's not the same thing when we're talking about pantheism. We're talking about the idea that God is literally part of everything.
- 2:10 So in a pantheistic way, God would be in me just as much as in the camera that I'm speaking to, as this table, as this Bible, as this marker, as this whiteboard, rocks, trees — pretty much all of it. All of nature is part of the divine. It's all part of who God is. It's all part of this divine sort of idea of the universe that's all combined into one. There's a divine spark in everything. That's essentially what pantheism teaches. So that's where we get this idea of essence, or force. When we talk about Star Wars, the idea of "may the force be with you" — that's the same kind of idea. It's a divine essence that's part of this. We can call it a force. There's something going on behind the scenes in everything else.

The key idea of distinction

- 3:09 So God is present everywhere. It defines life now, it defines life later, it defines relationships, it defines everything — how we see and relate to God. But the key I want you to get here is the idea of distinction, and this is going to be important as you move forward. If naturalism is saying there's no God at all, pantheism is saying, well, there is God, but God is not distinct from anything that's created. God is a part of creation, He's a part of you and me; there's just no distinction. There's no God and us. There's just everything all together. So for pantheism, there is no

distinction at all. Keep that in the back of your mind, especially as we move to next week when we talk about monotheism. That's going to be really, really important.

Paul at the Areopagus

3:59 In our Bible study portion, we talk about Paul. We talk about Paul's interaction at the Areopagus on Mars Hill, and we talk about his interaction between the Epicureans and the Stoics. What's interesting is that these Stoics actually believed much of the same kinds of things that modern-day pantheism believes — that idea that God is somehow packed into every little piece of our world. And what Paul does is help them see that there is a distinction between the two: that God is here and we are here. That there's a separation. That although He's personal, although He's right here with us, He's distinct and other than us. And that's incredibly important.

4:53 Because what this does — the loss of distinction — is actually what leads us to the root of all sin, right? Of creating God, or creating idols that are a substitute for God. If you say that there's no distinction, then all of these things are just as divine as God. So I can worship rocks and trees and everything else. It's not any different if we don't have some kind of distinction. So it drives us right back to the root of our sin. It drives us right back to idolatry.

Pantheism in Western culture

5:26 Your students probably won't see it right away, but you need to help them begin to see how Western culture has actually embraced a lot of pantheistic ideas about God and creation. Again, let's go back to the buffet. It's super easy for us to say, "Wow, that sounds really cool," because I can see how beautiful creation is and want to make that into a God-like thing. Or I can treat somebody, or an activity, that way — or I can find a center in myself and be that kind of person and elevate myself to a God-like stature. That sounds really cool.

6:06 And along the buffet line, it sounds like I can say, well, if I care about people, I can elevate them to that same status too. So I like justice; that seems to speak to some of my morality. Again, you start to go back to that buffet and start to piece things together. But when we put them all together, we realize once again that this isn't coherent and it isn't consistent.

Speak truth in love

6:31 Now, one quick word of note here that I want to make sure we're clear on. If you're doing everything really, really well, chances are you have some students who are either seeking or maybe skeptical, who have some questions and are curious. And as we're talking about other worldviews — whether they believe these things specifically or not — you want to be careful that we don't offend. We want to be careful that we speak truth, that we do so in love, but that we help them understand that these things are terribly inconsistent and they don't work.

7:12 But we need to do it without making fun of it. We need to do it without making light of it. Because when we're talking about worldviews, as we talked about a few weeks ago, these things are ingrained in us and they are embedded in us, and to change is a huge, monumental change, and it can often, like we said, create some anxiety. So the last thing we want to do is invite non-believing students, invite our seekers and our skeptics, into our youth space and say, "Come with

your questions, come with your curiosity, and we'll help you navigate — and we're going to accept you," but at the same time make light of or make fun of other worldviews. That's not going to work.

7:53 This is a very popular worldview. So is naturalism. There are some really, really smart people who have said some really, really intelligent things about these worldviews. Now, that doesn't make them true, but we have to respect what they believe and speak to how it does not line up with reality and how it does not line up with truth — but do so in love.

Remember this

8:16 So remember: pantheism says God is all. God is in everything and a part of everything — the rocks, the trees, everything — and it's a divine force. And essentially, the key word here is that there is no distinction between God and creation, between creator and creation. Not only does this lead to the idea of idolatry — if we don't have the distinction, what does that make God? The very fact that we call Him God means that He is completely distinct, completely other than us, and completely holy.

8:51 And the idea is this: if God is here and completely other than me, then I have a standard to look to, so I understand what's right and what's wrong. I understand what's just and unjust. I understand the idea of love versus hate. Putting God outside of myself and making God completely distinct helps us navigate reality in a way that makes sense. We have to have some kind of distinction. It's God who is other than, God who is holy, God who is supreme creator over all. And it's in Him that we live and move and have our being.